

We finally arrived in northern Kazakhstan near the Siberian border. A ramshackle village was to be our new home. The Poles could not leave here under the penalty of death. It was freezing cold, 20 degrees below zero. The locals were told they must shelter us, but they were also very poor; the NKVD allocated three or four families to a house. The locals were as good as they could be to us under the circumstances.

Immediately that freezing winter, I needed to use my gold: I first bartered with a man to acquire better living quarters and then I exchanged with a local man some gold chain links and coins for a fair sum of rubles. I used these to get bread and food for the remainder of that winter, which was brutal. I also bought tools and worked cutting wood, fixing stairs, or other odd jobs for a few rubles or more often food. I sometimes went days without food so that my daughter and wife could eat. We managed to survive the first harsh winter and the following summer, and despite my coming down with malaria and my wife almost dying of typhus. We were able to get medicine and food from those who had it—as long as we had some gold. Zlotys (Polish currency) had never been accepted, rubles were, but gold was now preferred over anything.

Finally, one day in 1942, the exiled Poles were summoned by the local NKVD. We were being released, we suddenly were free to go—with no reason being given.

(Germany had attacked Russia on June 22, 1941, and the Poles, by agreement, were to be released from the gulag to form an army in Persia.)

I asked a Russian official. He said, “Marion, get to the train station and get on a train as fast as possible before they change their minds.”

We left within hours. Many were simply too weak to go anywhere. Many simply remained. Upon arrival, we learned the Polish Army was being reformed, but the man in charge of the station was telling everyone that the trains were already overfull.

I very quietly made my way to the man in charge and offered him three gold coins, among my last, one for each of us—to get passage on the next train. He agreed. When the train arrived, he quietly motioned us around to the far side, spoke with another official, and they put us on the train, citing “special orders.” We were finally on our way out of that terrible place and were now among thousands of exiled Poles all racing south as fast as possible to get into General Anders’s Polish Army.

We crossed the Caspian Sea in a ship and arrived in Persia (Iran). We were lucky to be on that train, and on an early ship; later boats were turned back, the quota filled, they were sent back to Russia.

Most of us arrived in Persia emaciated. The local people took my family into their home those first weeks and nursed us back to health, and they were among the kindest people I have ever met.

I joined the Polish Second Corps under General Anders. Finally, there was hope for us. My wife and daughter were evacuated, though I thought they were on their way